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THE MAP · #02

The automation map for *law firms*

Everything we'd automate in a small or mid-size US firm, department by department: what each piece does, the software it lives in, and the person who approves it. Use it to plan your own setup, or to check what an agency is offering you.

01 Where the hours go

1 in 3

firms delay their invoices because timesheets are incomplete. Only 29% use automated tools for billing.

Source: Smokeball, 2025 State of Law report, survey of 310 US legal professionals (reported by LawSites, 17 Mar 2025). Smokeball sells practice management software.

35%

of 1,200 calls to small and mid-size US firms went unanswered during business hours, over four weeks.

Source: Law Leaders "Silent Lines" study, press release 13 Aug 2025. Law Leaders sells intake services, so treat it as their own data.

Most firms don't have a single big problem. They have small leaks in every department: an enquiry nobody sorts, a letter retyped from the intake form, a client who calls to ask where their case is, an hour of work that never makes it onto a timesheet.

02 The map

DEPARTMENT	WHAT WE'D AUTOMATE	WHO APPROVES
FRONT DOOR	Every web, phone and email enquiry sorted by practice area, key facts pulled out, and a conflict check run against your contacts before anyone calls back. Urgent matters page the attorney on call. Built into Lawmatics or Clio Grow.	**Intake lead accepts or declines**
ENGAGEMENT	Engagement letter and fee agreement drafted from the intake answers, in your own template, then sent for e-signature.	**A lawyer signs off every letter**
CASE WORK	Medical records, police reports and disclosure bundles indexed, and a draft chronology or summary prepared from them.	**Paralegal reviews and corrects**
CLIENTS	"Where is my case?" answered with a plain-English update drafted from your Clio milestones, on a schedule or on request.	**Fee earner approves before sending**
BILLING	Sent emails, calls and documents turned into draft time entries against the right matter.	**You approve in one pass, weekly**
CASH	Polite reminders on unpaid invoices, and any trust account entry that doesn't match a matter flagged.	**Accounts team handles every flag**

Also worth automating once the core is in: review and referral requests when a matter closes, and (for UK firms) ID and anti-money-laundering checks pushed straight into the case file.

03 Where we'd start: billing

Time capture is the first build we'd suggest for most firms, for three reasons:

- **It finds money you already earned.** Work that happened but never reached a timesheet.

- **No client ever sees it.** If a draft entry is wrong, the only person who notices is you, before anything is billed.
- **It's small.** It needs read access to email and calendar, your matter list in Clio, and your billing codes.

> How the approval works: every Friday you get one list of draft entries. Approve, edit or delete each one. Nothing goes on a bill until you say so.

04 Where custom software beats off-the-shelf

Sometimes the gap isn't a missing automation, it's a missing tool. Common ones we see for firms:

- **A client status page** built from your Clio milestones, for clients who will never log in to a portal.
- **An internal dashboard** showing intake, unbilled time and overdue invoices in one place for the managing partner.
- **Your own product.** If your firm has a process other firms would pay for, that can become software. We build MVPs too.

05 The rules every build follows

> **No system gives legal advice, quotes a fee, or assesses a case.** It collects facts, drafts, sorts and reminds. A person at the firm decides.

- **Client data stays in your systems** (your practice software and tools under a signed agreement), never pasted into a public chatbot.
- **Every draft has a named approver**, listed in the map above.
- **Lawyers stay responsible for AI-assisted work.** ABA Formal Opinion 512 (July 2024) covers competence, confidentiality, client communication and fees when firms use generative AI. Check your state bar's guidance too.

06 5 questions to ask any agency before you buy

1. **Does it work inside my practice software, or beside it?**
   Ask them to show it writing into Clio or Lawmatics live, not a demo account.
2. **Where does client data go?**
   Get a list of every service that touches it, and the agreement for each.
3. **Who approves each step?**
   If the answer is "nobody, it's fully automatic", walk away.
4. **Who fixes it when it breaks?**
   A name and a response time, in writing.
5. **What's the smallest first build?**
   A good partner proves one piece before selling you the rest.

Want this mapped to your firm?

Orbiqon builds automation across your whole firm, custom tools where off-the-shelf falls short, and MVPs when you want your own product. We'll look at how your firm runs today and show you what we'd build first. 20 minutes, no pitch deck.

Book a call at orbiqon.com

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